

Question 45 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Explain the Kirkpatrick model for evaluating training effectiveness.

Introduction

Evaluating training is Stage 4 of the training cycle. The notes say the process does not end when training is completed; effectiveness must be valued against outcomes, and outcomes must be related to the objectives of the programme. Besides trainees' reactions (affective outcomes), results are evaluated on learning that occurred, behaviour changes, and impact on corporate objectives.

Donald Kirkpatrick's four-level model is the standard way HRD students are expected to organise this idea. The four levels are usually seen as a ladder: each level is harder to measure and more important for the organisation. Liking a programme is not the same as improving the organisation's results.

Detailed points

- 1. Level 1 — Reaction.** Did participants like the programme? Did they find it relevant, comfortable, well taught? Measured by end-of-course feedback forms, often called smile sheets. Useful for improving hospitality, timing and trainer style. Danger: a funny trainer on a hill station can score 9/10 while nobody learned a skill.
- 2. Level 2 — Learning.** Did they acquire the intended knowledge, skill or attitude? Measured by written tests, demonstrations, pre-test versus post-test, role-play scores against a checklist. If level 2 is weak, later levels cannot honestly succeed. Example: a safety course must show that people can list lock-out steps and perform them on a dummy.
- 3. Level 3 — Behaviour (transfer to the job).** Do they use the learning at work after some weeks? Measured by observation, supervisor ratings, 360-degree comments, call audits, work samples. This is where most programmes die, because bosses, old habits and rewards pull people back. HRD climate decides much of level 3.
- 4. Level 4 — Results.** Did the organisation benefit — quality, productivity, errors, sales, safety, customer satisfaction, cost, or other corporate objectives? Hard to prove that training alone caused the change, but this is why the company paid. Example: repeat customer complaints fall 20% after complaint-handling training plus coaching.
- 5. Logic of the hierarchy.** Favourable reaction helps people stay open to learning; learning is needed for new behaviour; behaviour should produce results. Each step can fail even if the previous succeeded. Therefore a professional does not stop at level 1.
- 6. Design implication.** Decide measures during TNA and design, collect baseline before training, and plan a 30–60 day follow-up. Evaluation is not an afterthought after the certificate distribution.
- 7. Importance for HRD.** Stops HRD from claiming success on attendance and tea quality. Supports strategic status of HRD. Helps diagnose: if reaction is high and behaviour is low, look at transfer climate, not only the slides.
- 8. Limitations of the model.** Cause-and-effect at level 4 is messy (many factors affect sales). Full four-level evaluation is costly; use it proportionately (critical safety training vs a one-hour talk). Still the best simple map of effectiveness for exams and for practice.

Conclusion. Explain Kirkpatrick's four levels — reaction, learning, behaviour, results — with measures and examples. State the ladder logic, the need to plan evaluation early, and two limitations. Effectiveness means not only 'did they enjoy?' but 'did they learn, do, and improve organisational outcomes?'